

fridayReview

THE HINDU

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T.S. Subramanian

When the priceless Chola bronzes from Sivapuram and Pathur villages in Tamil Nadu were returned to India in 1986 and 1991 after protracted legal battles in the U.S. and U.K., it created a sensation. A formidable team of experts from diverse fields helped repatriate the bronzes after they were smuggled abroad. On February 17, 1988, Justice Ian Kennedy of a London court, awarding the idol to Tamil Nadu, praised R. Nagaswamy, who testified in the case, as “an acknowledged expert in the field of Chola bronzes.” Then Director of the Tamil Nadu State Department of Archaeology, Nagaswamy was an epigraphist, iconographer, archaeologist, and scholar of Tamil and Sanskrit.

It was celebration time again for epigraphists and scholars of Chola history when Leiden University in the Netherlands handed over the Anaimangalam copper-plate charter, popularly known as the Leiden plates, to Prime Minister Narendra Modi at The Hague on May 16, 2026.

Repatriating smuggled artefacts to their countries of origin is a tedious process. It involves prolonged court battles and testimonies from scholars, iconographers, epigraphists, forensic specialists and police officers. More importantly, the country in which the artefacts are discovered must be willing to return them, noted K. Muniratham, Director of Epigraphy, Archaeological Survey of India (ASI), Mysuru.

The roles played by ASI Director General Y.S. Rawat, S. Swaminathan, epigraphist and Professor Y. Subbarayalu, a scholar of Chola history, were crucial in persuading The Netherlands to return the plates to India. “We had been trying for the past 14 years. The real process began in 2024, when UNESCO asked me to prepare a dossier on the Leiden plates. I did so, with the help of epigraphist Swaminathan. We



Return of relics

The Leiden copper plates, repatriated to India from the Netherlands, are vital records of Chola governance, land grants and maritime links

worked closely with UNESCO,” said Munirathnam. The ASI also prepared a video presentation and successfully established the provenance of the plates, proving that they belonged to Tamil Nadu but had been taken to Holland. “We have brought back 155 artefacts in the last 13 years,” he added.

Lennart Bes, assistant professor, Indian and Asian History, Institute for History (Colonial and Global History), Leiden University, wrote to Subbarayalu, seeking clarifications.

According to Subbarayalu, “South Indian historians regard the two sets of Leiden copper plates, weighing about 30 kg and held by the university since 1862, as important sources for 11th-century history. While thousands of stone inscriptions document Chola history, copper-plate grants are comparatively rare. These plates, therefore, are

invaluable records.”

The statement of Leiden University's Colonial Collections Committee (CCC), which conducted an independent provenance investigation before deciding to return the plates, noted that the artefacts were “most likely excavated during the construction of Fort Vijf Sinnen and the redevelopment of the site at the Chinese Pagoda in Nagapattinam by the Dutch East India Company (VOC) between 1687 and 1700. At the time, the VOC had captured Nagapattinam. The plates had been carefully buried in the ground, most likely to protect them during a period of upheaval.” Florentius Camper “brought” the plates to the Netherlands in 1712, and they were later donated to Leiden University in 1862.

“The Leiden copper plates relate to the Chulamani Vihara, a Buddhist establishment in Nagapattinam, an important port town of the Chola kingdom. The institution, and the grants made to it by the Chola kings, testify to the strong international ties between South India and Southeast Asia,” explained Subbarayalu.

The copper plates consist of two sets. The larger set comprises 16 Tamil plates and five engraved in Sanskrit in Grantha script. The inscriptions on the larger plates reveal that the Sailendra king, Sri Mara Vijayotunga Varman of Srivijaya (Java), approached Rajaraja Chola I (r. 985-1014 CE) for permission to build a Buddhist vihara at Nagapattinam, in memory of his father, Sri Chulamani Varman. Rajaraja granted permission in 1006 CE and endowed the vihara with revenues from land in Anaimangalam village, including 8,943 kalam (a unit of measurement) of paddy and other materials for its maintenance.

The Chulamani Vihara was also called Raja Raja Perum Palli (a big vihara). Another vihara built at Nagapattinam was named Rajendra Chola Perum Palli. So there were two Buddha viharas at Nagapattinam.

An intriguing tale surrounds the golden Buddha idol once installed in the Chulamani Vihara. In his Substack article dated November

15, 2025, T.S. Krishnan, a specialist on the Chola, Pandya, Chera and the Nayaka dynasties, and author of several books wrote: “... it is important to address a piece of misinformation often repeated – that Tirumangai Azhwar, one of the Vaishnava saints, robbed a golden Buddha statue from the Vihara and used it to build the Srirangam temple wall. There is no historical evidence for this claim. Records refer to the monastery as ‘Chudamani Vihara,’ which was constructed centuries after Tirumangai Azhwar's time.”

Referring to the plates, Krishnan said, “They are not merely inscriptions. They are living evidence of Chola administration, land grants, maritime connections, Tamil-Southeast Asian relations,



Slice of the past (Clockwise from above) The royal seal of the Cholas; Brihadeeswara temple built by Rajendra Chola I at Gangaikonda Cholapuram; and the Leiden copper plates.

PHOTOS: V. VEDACHALAM; ISTOCK; AND PTI

and the civilisational confidence of the Chola age.”

Nagaswamy felt that people wrote on metal for two reasons. One was the belief that inscribing mystical diagrams (yantras) on metal would bestow spiritual powers; the other was to create durable documents.

All the major dynasties of the Tamil region and the Vijayanagara dynasty issued these copper plate inscriptions, which were discovered at different places and times. Some were unearthed by farmers while ploughing fields; others were found in locked rooms or religious mutts. “They are

replete with historical facts and together with stone records have benefitted historians and archaeologists. Fascinating as they may seem, these copper plate inscriptions are broad sheets of copper, held together by a thick ring passing through holes in the plates, and crowned by the seal of the dynasty that issued them,” said R. Balasubramanian, former curator, Government Museum, Chennai.

Somehow, Rajaraja's command was not engraved on the copper plates as was the custom. After he attained *deva thanmai* (his passing) as the inscription mentions, his son ‘Madurantaka’ Rajendra Chola I got his father's decree engraved on the copper plates. “This is mentioned in the Sanskrit portion,” shared veteran epigraphist V. Vedachalam.

“Importantly, the word ‘Anaimangalam’ has been carved in Tamil on the ring that connects the larger plates,” he pointed out.

The seal on the larger plates features a tiger, the royal emblem of the Cholas, the twin fish of the Pandyas, and the bow of the Cheras, flanked by two fly-whisks and two lamps – symbols of royal authority. Around these runs a Sanskrit sloka praising Rajendra.

The smaller plates were issued by Kulottunga Chola I (r. 1070-1120 CE) in 1090 CE, after two emissaries – Raja Vidhyadhara Sri Samanthan and Abhimanonthunga Sri Samanthan – from a Javanese ruler met him to seek reconfirmation of Rajaraja's earlier grant, as the rulers had since changed. Kulottunga not only reaffirmed the grant but also augmented it, endowing additional land and 4,400 kalam of paddy to the Chulamani Vihara. The seal on these plates bears a brief Sanskrit shloka in praise of Kulottunga I, underscoring both royal patronage and the continued ties across the seas.

Subbarayalu said he had once visited the Leiden University library and observed the care taken by its officials to preserve the plates for so long. He requested ASI officials to take good care of the plates and provide access to scholars to study them.

CULTUREBRIEFS

Tribute to Kalyanaraman

Senior musician Bhushany Kalyanaraman will release a book featuring seven thillanas of her guru, vidwan Thanjavur S. Kalyanaraman (also known as SKR) on June 2 at an event to mark his birth anniversary. It will be held at Arkay Convention Centre, 6.15 p.m. On the occasion, an album featuring the thillanas will also be released on YouTube. The initiative aims to help students learn these compositions. The thillanas are set in ragas such as Darbari Kanada, Brindavani, Dwijavanti, Kapi, Sindhu Bhairavi, Gavathi and Pahadi.

There will be performances by SKR's grand-nieces Akshaya Iyer and Aditi Iyer, and students of Bhushany Kalyanaraman — Madhuvanthi Badri and Archanashree. They will render SKR's compositions, and will be accompanied by Pakala Giridhar (violin) and B. Ganapathyraman (mridangam). This will be followed by Anuradha Sriram's vocal concert, featuring SKR's works including his dwi-madhyama raga creations.



Classical dance on digital stage

Aaha!, a digital dance festival, conceived by Aravinth Kumarasamy, the artistic director of the Singapore-based Apsaras Dance Company, will be launched on June 1. To be hosted on AVAL.video, the festival is being presented in collaboration with *The Hindu*.

A global meeting point for dancers, choreographers, musicians, scholars and rasikas, the festival aims to transform Bharatanatyam's presence on the digital platform. Specially commissioned solo, duet and ensemble works will be



showcased alongside conversations and behind-the-scene insights. It attempts to bridge the gap between tradition and innovation and will make artistes rethink performances in a digitally driven world. Curated by Mohanapriyan Thavarajah, associate creative director, Apsaras Dance Company, Aaha! features performances by 40 Bharatanatyam dancers across different categories including up-and-coming artistes, trailblazers, gurus and legends. The line-up includes Padma Subrahmanyam, the Dhananjayans, Priyadarsini Govind, Rama Vaidyanathan, Vaibhav Arekar and Meenakshi Srinivasan.



Engaging Scenes from Dharini Komal's *Sivasankari*. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT AND M. SRINATH



Sivasankari's stories on stage

V.V. Ramani

Popular writer Sivasankari's stories, written over a long and prolific career across a wide range of subjects, have long resonated with readers of Tamil periodicals. Selecting six from her vast repertoire, Dharini Komal has adapted them for the stage, presenting the collection as *Sivasankari* at the Vani Mahal theatre festival. Each of the selected stories explored themes whose core emotional values would resonate with viewers. The manner in which the plays were compiled was equally engaging – beginning with simple, light-hearted anecdotal pieces and gradually moving towards a more serious emotional territory, before culminating in a reflective, retrospective finale.

Kazhudhai Theyndhu is a

Six tales by the celebrated author were adapted by director Dharini Komal and presented at the Vani Mahal drama festival

simple story about a housewife's response to a newspaper advertisement seeking donations for a cause. Her instinctive generosity arising out of the situation slowly dissipates over time – a shift handled with gentle humour. The spontaneity and dialogue delivery by Vidya Lakshmi, as Poorna, livened up the scenes.

The second story, *Sandai*, which begins with a deep romance of a doting couple, gradually turns into serious antagonism, culminating in divorce. While it might have worked well as a short story, the dramatisation made the entire scenario appear contrived and unnatural. Shifting to a socio-political register, the next segment, *Thalaivar Vandhar*, is a

narrative on the unexpected benefits that accrue from the cancellation of a minister's visit. *Ayaah*, which centres on how a widowed village woman is treated and taken advantage of by her own

son and daughter-in-law, is a powerful commentary on the way many senior citizens are treated by their children today. Through subtle mannerisms, detailed characterisation and nuanced conveyance of emotions, ranging from happiness to sorrow and disillusionment, Nanjil Revathi brought depth to her

portrayal of Vadivambal. Details to the costume drape enriched the performance.

Deivam Ninru Kollum, a take on karmic retribution, and *Theppakulam* that takes a trip down memory lane, were intense, emotional stories that lent themselves well to theatrical exploration.

Is it coincidental that all stories were centred on women – their lives, emotions, and experiences? Barring one, in which Vignesh Chellapan as Parama Guru had a major role, the male characters largely served as fillers in the narratives. The stories featured actors Sahasranaman, Siddharth, Kaavya, Shashi Kumar, Anu Kannan, Kannan Ruthrapathy and Baby Subha.

Deviating from the usual painted stage settings, the use of LED projections (designed by Thiagarajan) added to the visual appeal. Lighting was handled by Cheta Ravi, and music was composed by Viswaajay. Dharini Komal's skilful direction – orchestrating the crisp flow of movements and scenes – combined with fine performances from the actors, sustained the momentum throughout.



Musical ode V. Subashri, with Mantha Sriramya on the violin and Kaushik Sridhar on the mridangam. PHOTO: S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

Aishwarya Raghunathan

The Music Academy became the stage for a carefully-curated thematic concert by V. Subashri, dedicated to the compositions of Purandaradasa – a 16th-century saint-composer hailed across generations as the Sangita Pitamaha. Born Srinivasa Nayaka, a prosperous but tight-fisted moneylender in Karnataka, he transformed into a wandering saint-poet after being moved by his wife's deep devotion to Vittala. Renouncing his wealth, he went on to compose works marked by a rare depth and immersiveness. He did not write from mere piety, but as someone who wrestled with the grip of material life. That tension—between worldly attachment and spiritual surrender –echoes through many of his kritis. Subashri, accompanied by Mantha Sriramya on the violin and Kaushik Sridhar on the mridangam, opened her recital with 'Sharanu siddhi vinayaka' in Sowrashttram – an invocatory plea seeking Ganesha's shelter through the word *sharanu*

Echoes of Dasa verses

V. Subashri performed an exclusive concert featuring Purandaradasa's compositions

(refuge, surrender). Purandaradasa often began his compositions with an act of surrender. Subashri set the tone without over-elaborating. The violin was restrained and Kaushik's playing was clean in sollu delivery. 'Nimma bhagya doddadho' in Begada followed. The kalpanaswaras were taken from Rama Nama – within the devotional frame of the piece. The violin contributed well in the swara passages. The mridangam support was unhurried. The piece concluded with the Mudra charanam. The briga-rich 'Dayamado ranga dayamado' in Kalyani sustained the concert's momentum. A brisk Atana alapana then introduced 'Sakala graha', providing a welcome shift in the mood and energy. The niraval, at

'Pakshi vahana deena rakshakanu neene' saw the violin functioning almost as an extension of the vocal line, responding with sensitivity to the contours of the phrase. Kalpanaswaras were concise and purposeful, that once again, was followed by the mudra charanam. 'Rama rama rama rama rama enniro sita' in Vasanta moved quickly through mel kala swaras, the mridangam registering the raga's character in its tone. Bhairavi formed the centrepiece of the concert. The alapana unfolded, traversing the raga's expansive landscape. While some voice breaks were noticeable in the lower register, the overall exploration retained its emotional coherence. The composition 'Odi barayya vaikunta pathi' followed, with

niraval at 'Nodi mathadi'. The subsequent kalpanaswaras were well-mounted, and the violin held its own charm throughout. Kaushik Sridhar's tani was earnest. The concert's final arc moved through the quietly meditative world of ugabhogas: 'Anuvige anuvagi' in Desh, and 'Hari embodhe' in Kalyana Vasantam and Durga, praising Hari across the shifting colours of the two ragas. These led into 'Mandamatiyu nanu', a composition of frank self-deprecation and complete surrender to Purandaravittala. It belongs to a long tradition in Bhakti poetry of the *dasya* disposition, the stance of the servant, where the devotee approaches the divine not with any claim to worthiness but with the bare fact of longing. After the emotional weight carried through the evening, it arrived with the force of a quiet conclusion. The concert came to a close with the famous 'Bhagyada lakshmi baramma' in Madhyamavati. The audience's readiness to receive each of these with warmth spoke for Dasa's enduring place in every Carnatic music listener's musical memory.

A digital paradox

Tamil play *thanimAI* captures the irony of a young man building an app to ease loneliness, yet unsettled by the steady stream of visitors at home

Suganthi Krishnamachari

In Dummies Drama's *ThanimAI* (story: Nithya Kaushik; direction: Nithya Kaushik and Sreevathson), staged at Krishna Gana Sabha, Aditya, a computer science graduate from IIT, and a fellow IITian Vivek (Karthik Bhat) run a company about to launch an app designed to help introverts find friends. On the eve of the launch, an AI agent detects a bug in the app but doesn't point out what it is. Aditya has less than 24 hours to find and fix it. He decides to work from home. The stakes are high for Aditya, because the foreign investor expresses his displeasure at the last minute glitch. Unfortunately, Aditya struggles to concentrate on his work. His father Viswanathan, a compulsive talker arrives unannounced. Then comes a man looking for his wife Lakshmi, who

does the housekeeping, followed by a cable TV technician. And then there is a steady stream of visitors. The play captured the paradox of the digital age, where everyone is connected via the net, and yet many experience loneliness. It is ironic that Aditya, who is eager to provide a digital solution for human connection, is annoyed by the very presence of people in his house. The dialogues were sharp and did not bog the audience down with technical details. Sridhar's portrayal of Viswanathan was so natural that it didn't seem like a stage performance. You had the uncanny feeling of peering into Aditya's apartment and watching Sridhar solve the problems of the youngsters around him. Swaminathan as Aditya conveyed well the anxiety about work and frustration at being interrupted by frequent visitors. While Aditya's app might have been glitchy, the play itself was flawlessly executed.



Well-executed ThanimAI. PHOTO: M. SRINATH

CALENDAR

Jayanti celebrations

Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, under the auspices of Neela Subramanian Endowment and in association with Veda Pata Nidhi Trust, celebrates the 132nd jayanti of Sri Chandrasekharendra Saraswati on May 31, 6 p.m., at Bhavan's P.A.C. Hall, East Mada Street, Mylapore. The evening programme includes special puja, veda parayanam and a discourse 'Mahaperiyavalum Guruguhanum', to be presented by R. Vijayalakshmi.

Honour for Sudha Ragunathan

Senior vocalist Sudha Ragunathan was honoured with the Sangetha Saagara award by CMANA (Carnatic Music Association of North America), one of the oldest Carnatic music organisations in the U.S., on May 25. The award was presented in recognition of her contribution to field.

KFA awards

Kartik Fine Arts presents the Kartik Rajagopal 35th Kodai Nataka Vizha award distribution function on June 1, 5.30 p.m. at TAG Mylapore Fine Arts Club auditorium. Shree Varma, CMD, Shree Varma Group of Wellness Institutions will be the chief guest and will present the awards in different categories. P. Muthukumaran receives the Kartik Ramanujam Award of Excellence for Best Theatre Artiste. The Nadigar Thilagam Shri Sivaji Ganesan Award for all-round excellence will be presented to Dummies Drama's play *ThanimAI*. This will be followed by the staging of UAA's *Varadu Kutty - Parikshaiku Neramachu 2* at 7 p.m.



Sanjana Ganesh
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By the time Nicky Chandam set-up her first camera at a folk performance in Delhi's Nehru Park around 2010, she wasn't thinking about exhibitions. She was simply watching. A self-described introvert, who grew up in Imphal's valley, Nicky found performance art both terrifying yet beckoning – like the waves on a beach, she says.

"You know that when it hits you, you feel light. But at the same time, you are afraid the waves might carry you along." Photography became the shore she stood on, close enough to feel the pull.

Her exhibition – 'Manipur & Archives: A Visual Documentation of Live Art Over a Decade' – opened in Chennai on May 27 and runs through May 31. It is her second show in the city, one she has been trying to mount for two years.

Presented at Alliance Française

A lens that listens

Manipur-based Nicky Chandam's Chennai photo exhibition explores the politics of performance

Madras, the show brings together 58 carefully-selected photographs spanning 2011 to 2025 – a distillation of images that document Manipuri performance cultures across Delhi and Imphal.

The exhibition foregrounds the work of a woman photographer from the Northeast, whose practice

maps performance spaces within India. The exhibition which started with a conversation about theatre and live performance with exponent A. Mangai last evening; continues with an evening of ghazal and poetry today by the Amir Khusro Sangeet Academy, a conversation with filmmaker

A scene from 'Postcard Kabui Keioiba Kerala' by School of Drama and Fine Arts, Thrissur



Someetharan on making art in conflict zones on May 30, and the screening of *Pebet* on May 31.

The photographs on display read like a cross-section of India's live art landscape. Astad Deboo's 'Rhythm Divine' – a blend of Pung Cholom and Manipuri dance – represents its Delhi staging at Kamani Auditorium and its Imphal performance at Chandrakriti Auditorium. There is Mamata Shankar in 'Amritasya Putra', Parvathy Baul in the collaborative 'Raha', Ratan Thiyam's *Macbeth* performed at Bharat Rang Mahotsav, and the 'One Thousand and One Nights' from the Asia Meets Asia tour. 'Manipuri Raas' at the India International Centre and the Koodiyattam play *Surpanakhankam* are also among the documented works. The most recent image – and perhaps the most charged – is of Heisnam Sabitri in *Pebet*, directed by Heisnam Kanhailal, captured at its 50th anniversary celebration in Imphal in 2025. A video recording of this performance will be screened on the concluding day of

the exhibition.

For Nicky, performance photography demands a particular kind of invisibility. "I have to be invisible to the audience and the performer. From there, I pick up one moment."

What that moment can hold, she explains, is something video cannot – the single instant when a face opens, or when an emotion, slow or intense, crests. Nicky recalls a 2014 image of a 70-year-old folk singer who, mid-song, compared the sweetness of a fruit to a mother's milk. "The emotion that came over his face – that photograph is still there, and I remember it even today," she shares.

Although the exhibition has now arrived in Chennai, she has tried several times to organise it in Manipur.

Since the ethnic conflict that erupted on May 3, 2023, artists were among the first to be targeted – a rock-group's musical instruments were seized, and programmes cancelled at the first sign of unrest.

"No engineers were asked to stop their work. No doctors. No offices. But artists were the main target." The unpredictability of life in the valley has made staging anything there nearly impossible today," she says.

It is evident that the stakes of archiving, then, are not merely curatorial. Each photograph preserves what Nicky calls the "atmospheric dynamics and collaborative energies" of a performance ecology under pressure. At its core, she says, her practice is an act of resistance, especially as she also moonlights as a photographer who captures the streets of Imphal where she lives. She carries out her vision quietly and patiently from behind the lens.

Nicky belongs to the Meitei community, which is embroiled in conflict with the Kuki-Zo tribe. She describes the violence in the State as revolting, particularly because it has caused immense loss of lives, and a complete breakdown of community bonding beyond rigid partisan lines. "At this point, there seems to be no possibility of peace," she shares, visibly distressed. "If such a conflict had happened in any other mainland state, the response would have been different. If countries can negotiate ceasefires, I wonder why that remains a distant reality for Manipur," she asks, adding that the conflict is infinitely-layered.

"All art is political, that much is true."

Her photographs, captured in different tones of black and white and showcasing ancient and contemporary art forms, carry the weight of that statement.

The exhibition is on at Alliance Française Madras in Nungambakkam. Entry is free.



Lasting resonance

A memorial festival by the Dr. Prabha Atre Foundation celebrated the maestro's inventive ragas, lyrical precision and the values she instilled in generations of disciples

Shailaja Khanna

Few artistes manage to leave behind a legacy as profound as the music they create in their lifetime. Prabha Atre was one such musician. Earlier this month, a memorial tribute curated by the Pune-based Dr Prabha Atre Foundation, which she had established, served as a reminder of her extraordinary artistry – her distinctive interpretations of ragas, her meticulously crafted compositions balancing swara and lyric and her pioneering spirit in conceiving new ragas. Beyond her creative genius, she stood tall as an

empowering guru, shaping generations with her vision and voice.

The two-day festival titled NavRaag Prabha was a thoughtfully-curated event. Four of her senior disciples – Atindra Sarvadikar, Arati Thakur Kundalkar, Ashvini Modak, and Chetna Pathak – each of whom trained under Prabha Atre for more than two decades, presented 17 ragas conceived and composed by her.

Interestingly, Prabha Atre composed three ragas using Malhar as the base, weaving in other notes to create ragas that were uniquely distinct. These are Patdeep Malhar, Kafi Malhar, and Gara Malhar. She



did not wholly subscribe to the time theory of presenting ragas, arguing that the conditions for rendering them have changed over the centuries. She also believed that listeners without musical training – who lack the pre-conditioned receptivity of listening – may not find ragas performed at the "wrong" time unsettling. While a trained listener might be bewildered to hear a morning raga performed at night, many in the audience without such prior knowledge would simply

Tribute notes (From far left) Prabha Atre; Chetna Pathak; Ashvini Modak; Arati Thakur Kundalkar and Atindra Sarvadikar. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

connect with the music as it was presented. She argued that performers recording a raga prescribed for a different time in a studio were compelled to realize that the mood of the raga had to be created independently of the external environment. For instance, Patdeep, an afternoon raga, when joined with Malhar, a rainy-season raga, and rendered in the early evening by Atindra Sarvadikar, proved deeply melodious.

There are three ragas that use Malkauns as their parent scale: Madhurkauns, Bhinnakauns, and Darbari Kauns.

Arati Thakur Kundalkar shared how she had been taught Madhurkauns. "Tai (Prabha Atre) was a gentle soul who brought that same softness into her music. In Madhurkauns, which I presented, she was particular about how the two gandhars in the raga were to be rendered. They should not be sung as one note following another in a staccato manner; instead, they must flow with a meend, seamlessly moving from one note to the next without any jarring effect."

Prabha Atre also used Kalyan as the base for two ragas – Apurva Kalyan and Bhoop Kalyan. Apurva Kalyan is a subtle blend of Purvi and Kalyan, though some feel it resembles Puriya Kalyan more

closely, with a strongly emphasised shuddha madhyam. That is the beauty of her creations: the merging of notes is delicate, nuanced and always open to interpretation.

Another raga that deeply fascinated the maestro was Bhairav. She wove it into three new creations – Tilang Bhairav, Kaushik Bhairav, and Ravi Bhairav. The compositions she crafted for each were equally significant, with lyrics carefully aligned to the mood she envisioned for the raga. Arati Kundalkar reflected: "Since I sing compositions of many other composers, I realise the uniqueness of tai's approach. She chose words with great care, fitting them neatly into the framework of the composition. In Tilang Bhairav, the piece is dedicated to Shiva, the presiding deity of Bhairav: 'Hey Shivashankar, karunakar, tu hai aadhar, paap uttaro bhavsagar, hey shambho gangadhar, tu hai aadhar'."

Unusually, Prabha Atre trained under her gurus of the Kirana gharana – Pt. Suresh Babu Mane and Vidushi Hirabai Barodekar – for no more than five years. She often shared that she never felt the need to approach another guru; the material she had assimilated during that brief period took a lifetime to process, absorb, and build upon. Fortunately, her disciples seem to have imbibed her values, displaying the same openness and integrity toward music in their presentations.

CALENDAR

Annual music competition

Shakthi Sangita Sabha, Valasaravakkam, announces its annual music competition for those in the eight to 24 year age group. Those selected for the final round will perform on July 26. The competition is spread over five categories – Carnatic vocal, semi-classical vocal, Carnatic instrumental, percussion solo and Tirumurai rendition Last date is May 31. Link for online registration: <https://forms.gle/PrKdskYmLLNQ19bq6>. For more details call 94455 25823 or send a mail to shakthisangitasabha@gmail.com

Tamil play

Under the auspices of Chromepet Cultural Academy, Mapillai Ganesh's Sathyasai Creations will stage its Tamil play *Yaamini En Kanmani* on May 31, 6.45 p.m. at CCA hall.



Planning for Parenthood

When a couple begins to think about starting a family, we as doctors suggest a roadmap of sorts, from pre-pregnancy planning to detailed evaluation, which will give us the necessary information to find a suitable direction for the couple.

Pre-Pregnancy Planning & Tests

The pre-pregnancy planning process begins with detailed history. For men, childhood illnesses such as mumps can have a lasting impact on sperm production, as can past injuries or surgeries involving the groin or reproductive organs. For women, menstrual patterns, previous surgeries, and underlying conditions affecting the uterus or ovaries are important information markers.

Baseline Tests

These include general health markers such as haemoglobin levels, blood sugar levels and thyroid function.

Understanding Hormonal Balance

An important test is the Anti-Müllerian Hormone (AMH) test,

which provides insight into ovarian reserve. Other hormones, including FSH, LH, and prolactin, clarify how regularly and effectively ovulation is occurring. In men, hormonal testing may be recommended if there are concerns about sperm production.

Carrier Screening

Genetic carrier screening tests identify whether either partner carries genes for inherited conditions or genetic disorders.

If Conception Takes Longer...

If a couple is trying for several months to a year without success, the focus shifts to understanding why conception hasn't occurred. For women, a pelvic ultrasound helps assess the uterus and ovaries. Ovulation tracking may also be recommended. For men, a semen analysis helps evaluate sperm count, movement, and structure.

Looking Deeper

If initial findings suggest underlying concerns, advanced testing may be



Dr. K.S. Kavitha Gautham, MBBS, MS (OG) Managing Director, BloomLife Hospital Pvt. Ltd.

advised. For women, this may include checking whether the fallopian tubes are open through procedures like HSG, or examining the uterine cavity through hysteroscopy. Ovulation may be tracked more precisely through follicular monitoring. For men, advanced sperm tests can provide deeper insight into sperm quality.

Finding the Right Direction

The key purpose of these tests is to guide decisions. With a greater sense of clarity and understanding, couples can make the most important shift of all—not waiting for answers, but choosing to begin with them.

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Deccan's untold love story

Mohammad Ali Baig's film, *Chand Tara*, revisits Hyderabad's past through the bond between Taramati and Sultan Abdullah Qutb Shah

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Despite its immense contribution to poetry and lyricism, the Qutb Shahi dynasty, rulers of the Golconda Sultanate from 1518 to 1687, is significantly less celebrated and depicted in cinema than the Mughals. Mohammad Ali Baig, a pioneering figure in heritage theatre, has been reviving the history, folklore and secular ethos of Sultan Muhammad Quli Qutb Shah (founder of Hyderabad) and his legacy. Baig's latest venture is *Chand Tara*, a feature film on the legend of Taramati and Sultan Abdullah Qutb Shah, grandson of Quli Qutb Shah (who reigned from 1626 to 1672), captures the bond he shared with singer Taramati. Baig holds their legend as more than just a quaint regional story or a standard fairy-tale romance. "It is a window into the highly sophisticated, syncretic, and artistic world of the 17th century Deccan," says the actor-director, who just returned from Cannes, where the trailer and poster of the film were released at the National Film Development



Corporation-managed Bharat Pavilion to an "overwhelming response". The catalyst for the film was rooted in Baig's first theatre production, *Taramati*, which he staged at the historic Taramati Baradari in Hyderabad. "The monument was built in her memory by Sultan Abdullah Qutb Shah, a connoisseur of arts and grandson of Sultan Quli Qutb Shah, the first Sahib-e-Diwan poet of Urdu." Inspired by his mother, Begum Razia, Baig says, "Most of my work in theatre is woman-oriented. Women with their dignity, strength, and

calm can change things around. Taramati did the same - with the worship of her art, and her grit and determination - she turned a mama's boy into an able administrator." Baig says very little is available about Taramati except that Premamati, whom she considered a sister figure, was a dancer in Sultan Abdullah's court. "It is a historical fact that Taramati lived in that era, and she is buried in the private necropolis of the Qutb Shahi tombs, which is a heritage site today." It is also true, he adds, that Sultan Abdullah Shah, a patron of the arts, gave the



village of Kuchipudi to dancers and artistes. "We have fictionalised their story a bit. It is not known whether Taramati was a begum or court singer but we do understand that she resisted being a court singer because she believed her art was her worship. That a monument built by the king of that period stands in memory of a singer, who was neither his queen nor a consort, also tells a story." When stripped of modern romanticisation, the story, Baig feels, reveals fascinating truths about early Medieval Indian geopolitics, gender dynamics, music, and architecture.

Reflecting on the conjectures about their relationship, the actor-director says it is not a love story. "Taramati and Sultan Abdullah met at a stage of their lives when they were mature enough to understand that they may not have a future together. Taramati resists going to the Sultan's court and refuses his calls, but when they meet, she realises that he is a cultured man who loves the arts as much as she does. She falls in love with him, but this bond is beyond romance. It is a mature, spiritual, and intellectual connection." The highlight of the music is the recreation of 'Piya baaj



Royal tale Scenes from Mohammad Ali Baig's new film *Chand Tara*. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



pyaala' (without my beloved, I cannot live a single moment) – a popular nazm by Sultan Quli Qutb Shah that is part of Deccani folklore. "It has been used several times before and is about the longing for the beloved. I have used it where Sultan Abdullah sends this nazm through Premamati after Taramati refuses to go to the darbar. I think composer Karthik Raja has composed it beautifully, and singer Vasundhara Das has done justice to it," says Baig, who has also written the lyrics for a couple of songs. With talent drawn from across the country, Baig says it

is a pan-Indian film. With voice-over by Anupam Kher, the film features seasoned actors and singers such as Mohan Agashe, Masood Akhtar, and Lucky Ali, while theatre actor Ranjana Srivastava plays the lead role of Taramati. The past is often seen through the prism of today. "I am not trying to make a political statement, nor is my theatre. It is an attempt to present the history and heritage of Hyderabad, something I know firsthand because my family has witnessed it. I am neither glorifying nor demonising anyone."

Neha Kirpal
Mumbai based writer, performer and film-music composer-producer – Sameer Rahat – recently released an Urdu-electronica EP titled *Roz-marra*, a poetic project, where Urdu poetry meets contemporary electronica. "The term, *rozmarra* means daily routine or the ordinary. But Urdu has always had this profundity for ordinary things. It renders the quotidian many-folded, weighted with something you can't quite name," says Rahat. The songs were written over a decade with the last one just three months ago. The album was mainly recorded and produced in about 18 months, while Rahat shuttled between India and Europe – through cities, hotels, green rooms and kitchens – and what emerged was a record shaped like a single day. "The arc is quite dramatic, but also, it's just life, simple and repetitive."



Love of language Sameer Rahat and (below) poet-father Rahat Indori PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Hum of daily life

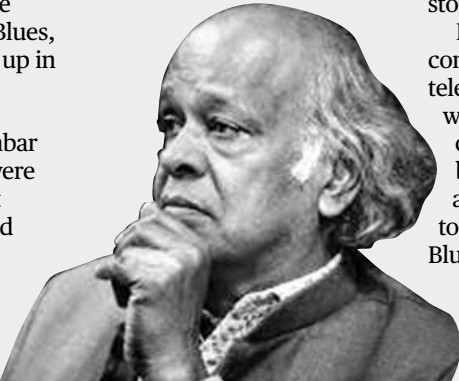
Sameer Rahat recasts Urdu poetry in electronic sound with *Roz-marra*

restlessness that lingers even when life seems ostensibly fine. "Vocal synths, a deep driving bass and an irresistible groove at its core – the morning it describes holds both contentment and displacement in the same breath," he says. 'Kaisa din' carries the weight of the afternoon and the feel of an ordinary day. The title track, co-written with Ditty, imagines the heart as a small town, where faces are printed like daily advertisements on its walls. "Somewhere in that noise, someone you once knew becomes a

stranger and the song quietly asks why we never reach out again. A gospel-like choir arrives to reinforce that central question, as if the everyday itself needs to be properly understood." The son of the legendary Urdu poet Rahat Indori and the force behind Urdu Blues, Sameer Rahat grew up in a home shaped by language. Both his parents, Anjum Rehbar and Rahat Indori, were poets, which meant mushairas happened regularly. "I was watching both of them hold rooms of thousands of

people with a single *sher* before I understood what any of it meant. That kind of early education doesn't leave you," he recalls. Music came slightly later and through a different door entirely – records, then guitars, and a prog-rock-band called Joshish that he founded at 16, where he wrote almost everything in Urdu. "The language had already moved in; the music simply followed," he says. His most ambitious record by far is his upcoming full-length album, *Purana*. It's about how the past moves through you, reshapes you and ultimately

becomes you. It feels like the beginning of a new sonic space; a new voice emerging from a familiar place. "If *Aamad* was the arrival and *Roz-marra* the daily motion in between, *Purana* is memory." For Rahat, the live practice never really stops. "Performance has always been the backbone of everything. It's where the songs first find their breath – in front of people, in real rooms. I perform in different settings depending on the night: sometimes solo, sometimes with a full seven-piece ensemble with horns and choir. Each version tells a different part of the same story." Rahat continues to compose for film and television while also writing lyrics for other composers. He has begun directing videos and now plans to put together a live Urdu Blues double album with some of the finest blues musicians in the world.



CULTUREBRIEFS

Pancharatna kritis on Pancha Sabhas

Shivanugraha Trust, Chennai, has organised a special concert featuring Rukmini Ramani's Pancharatna kritis, a unique collection of compositions on the Pancha Sabhas of Nataraja – Kanaka Sabha at Chidambaram, Rajata Sabha at Madurai, Tamira Sabha at Tirunelveli, Chitra Sabha at Courtallam and Ratna Sabha at Tiruvalangadu – on May 30 at Narada Gana Sabha Mini Hall. The evening will begin at 4.30 p.m. with the rendition of 'Sri natrajarin pancha sabhaigalin pancharatnam' with Rukmini Ramani leading the ensemble. Parur M.K. Ananthalakshmi will accompany on the violin and Kumbakonam A. Saravanan on the mridangam. This will be followed by Pylore A. Narayanan's vocal concert at 6.15 p.m. with C.S. Chinmayi on the violin and Sunaada Krishna Amai on the mridangam.

Classical concert

The Music Academy presents a special concert today at 6 p.m. to mark Mysore Sadasiva Rao, Mysore Jayachamaraja Wodeyar and Harikesanallur Muthiah Bhagavata Day. Vocalist Pavan Rangachar will lead the performance, alongwith M. Vijay on the violin and Chidambaram S. Balashankar on the mridangam. The programme, organised under the endowment instituted by Smt. Chandrika Rudrapatnam, will be held at the Kasturi Srinivasan Hall.

